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Ethical Guidance and Behaviors

A. Codes of ethics are similar to SOPs (standard operating procedures) except that these are based on principles. Using codes of ethics, professionals have a baseline of foundational principles they can follow in almost any given situation. It quite literally sets the expectations before problems arise, and it gives professionals specific principles to follow after they occur. There are two main ways a profession would be able to benefit from these codes of ethics. The first way is by offering trust between the profession and the public. The public is more likely to trust a profession if they have a written rulebook they honor, such as a code of ethics. The second way is through accountability. Since every employee is supposed to be following the same code of ethics, the profession is able to keep track of who is and who isn't meeting the standard. When an employee is found violating the code of ethics, they are disciplined accordingly. This is done to protect the reputation of everyone.

B. I selected Principle 1.2 Avoid Harm and Principle 1.7 Honor Confidentiality. Both of these principles align perfectly with my future career position as a cybersecurity GRC analyst. The reason Principle 1.2 Avoid Harm correlates perfectly with this position, is because it's a principle that focuses on preventing negative consequences, such as disclosure of sensitive information or damage to reputation. As a GRC analyst, my job is to prevent incidents from happening by following the correct security procedures, such as regular compliance auditing and flagging possible vulnerabilities (ACM Code, 2018). Principle 1.7 Honor Confidentiality is about keeping information entrusted to professionals secure (ACM Code, 2018). It requires professionals to protect information and not disclose it unless permitted. As a GRC analyst, this principle plays a big part when it comes to this role because I would be in charge of auditing and generating vulnerability reports before they're fixed. If this information were to fall into the wrong hands and get leaked, I would be putting clients and others at risk of harm due to my failure to keep information protected.

C1. In almost every job posting candidates are being filtered through an AI system nowadays known as an ATS (Applicant Tracking System) screening. Most of the time, this system automatically rejects applicants based on their qualifications and even who they are, such as their race, age, or gender. These systems were trained to automatically decide whether or not an application gets reviewed by a human. These AI systems learn from the company's historical hiring data. They analyze who was hired in the past and use that information to screen applications. For example, a large company that used this kind of system, Amazon, had an ATS tool that was training itself using 10 years of applicants that submitted their resumes. Because of this, it caught onto specific characteristics of the applicants. It noticed that a majority of the people applying were men so what it began doing was prioritizing the male candidates over

women (MIT Technology Review, 2018). Many people who apply for jobs rarely get their applications viewed by a human, regardless of whether they qualify or not. A candidate could have all the needed qualifications for the job position, but could be denied simply on one uncontrollable factor, who they are as a human being.

The second negative impact of AI bias is facial recognition. Specifically, when this technology is used by law enforcement, it tends to not be accurate, because most of the errors are usually biased. They tend to have a higher rate of error when attempting to identify people with certain skin complexions and facial features, such as eye shape. A study found that out of about 200 facial recognition algorithms, the system had trouble identifying Black and Asian faces 10 to 100 times higher than white faces (NIST, 2019). The worst performance was found when attempting to identify dark-skinned women. Many police departments use this facial recognition technology to identify potential suspects, but when the system gets this incorrect, the victims are the people who are accused because of something they can't change. This leads to unlawful arrests and greatly impacts the criminal justice system's credibility. In January 2020, there was a man named Robert Williams who was a victim to this AI facial recognition failure. He was in the driveway of his home and was inaccurately identified as a suspect because the software the Detroit police had been using had falsely matched him as a shoplifting suspect. Because of this, Williams was jailed for about 30 hours for a crime he didn't commit, and this was the first publicly reported unlawful arrest caused by the inaccuracy of facial recognition (ACLU, 2024).

C2. I believe that Principle 1.4 Be Fair and Take Action Not to Discriminate, best aligns with the negative impact I addressed previously, facial recognition. This principle requires professionals to treat everyone fairly and not to discriminate. It means that professionals are responsible for more than just their preconceived opinions. They need to be taking action that will prevent any forms of discrimination within the technology they use. If the software they had used was trained on a diverse group of the population, its accuracy would have been more balanced across each race. By following this principle, this also places accountability on the police department. They should not have been using a system known to misidentify people at a higher rate based on their ethnicity. The issue was that it was identifying the wrong people and linking them to crimes they didn't commit, simply based on their human features. If the developers of the software Detroit police had used followed this principle and tested it properly, they would've caught on to its inaccuracies before issuing it to officers, and Robert Williams, an innocent man, would never have been unlawfully arrested in front of his family (ACM Code, 2018).

References

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